

The Writing on the Wall

A mass movement took off, with street plays, songs, marches, street-corner meetings and door-to-door motivation programmes. The response was overwhelming. There was Mundi Muthassi, 106, determined to learn from Anthony, 69, a retired teacher in Cochin. Then there was the severely handicapped Sudharma, 14, who had never gone to school. Her father did not want her to be the only illiterate in Puthanvelakara and so carried her daily to the class. And more than the alphabet was being taught. The instructors spoke of basic health, sanitation, cleanliness, environment protection, nutrition and family welfare. Says Shashidharan, an instructor, "the idea was to integrate literacy and development". More significant still was the drive's social impact. The crime rate fell and Island Gothuruth—known for brewing of illicit liquor—shed its image as residents began to opt for respectable jobs. The Manjalloor panchayat reported that compulsive drinkers were giving up liquor. Schools reported a fall in the dropout rate. And neo-literates requested that attempts to educate them shouldn't be discontinued.

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literacy for the country. After Kottayam's achievement, neighbouring Ernakulam became the country's second fully-literate district in 1991, followed by Kerala, the first state to attain full literacy in the same year. A decade later, 587 of the country's 600 districts were covered under the Total Literacy Campaign (TLC) of which 202 districts have entered the post-literacy phase and the rest continue in the literacy phase. The effort saw India move up in its pursuit of universal literacy when the literacy rate grew from 52.21 per cent in 1991 to 65.38 per cent in the 2001 census, the biggest decadal jump—13.17 per cent—after independence, compared to the annual average 8 per cent in the preceding decades.

Even though it was no difficult step

NAMAS BHOJANI



BETTER LATE THAN NEVER: Women learning to read and write at a school for elders

for Kottayam, it was one of the few efforts ever witnessed in the politically polarised state in which everybody eagerly cooperated, cutting across class, creed, religion and caste politics. "In fact, we made participation in the campaign a matter of prestige and the flood of offers for voluntary cooperation became difficult to handle," remembers Alphons, who recently opted for voluntary retirement from the civil service to join politics.

The greatest initiative for the campaign came from the Kottayam-based Mahatma Gandhi University, which was led by Vice-Chancellor U. R. Ananthamurthy, a noted Kannada writer who took special interest in the campaign. Students spearheaded the campaign, holding classes for the illiterate. The media also took up the cause, carrying stories about 80-or-90-year-olds shedding their life-long stigma of being illiterate to acquire a new-found social status after attending adult literacy classes. "People were excited that Kottayam was soon to acquire a proud place on the world map. Hundreds of literate but unemployed women from

various parts of the district joined the massive campaign without accepting payment," says Alphons. Scores of social, religious and cultural organisations, business groups and others, also made a liberal contribution to the programme. The overwhelming voluntary spirit also helped the organisers tide over any financial constraints. That was, and is, the power of people. ■

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is the rate of literacy in the country in 2001, up from 52.21 per cent in 1991